Saving Grace

By Cynthia L. Cooper

Characters:
JaneAnne – a mature woman lab worker with a reasonable respect for Elvis. She speaks to an unseen investigative agent.

INTRODUCTION

We the undersigned, in our enduring love for Elvis, implore all those involved in cloning to hear our plea. One cell would allow future generations to witness his presence. The technology is here, and this petition is a testament to our will. Bacteria, sheep, monkeys—all cloned! Some fear the possibilities. I urge you to seize them. Americans for Cloning Elvis (ACE) requests your support. Make your view known around the world by signing our petition.

Seriously, the organization exists and likely prompted this monologue in response . . . Saving Grace by Cynthia L. Cooper

(JANEANNE, wearing a lab coat, sits at a bare unadorned desk, leaning across. Unseen is an investigator, to whom she speaks. She suddenly leans back, closes her eyes for a moment, and begins to sway in her seat. SHE takes a deep breath, opens her eyes and begins to sing, demonstrating great feeling if minimal ability.)

"Love me tender, love me true ..." 1956. Title of Elvis' first movie, too; same year. *(SHE hums.)*

So you don't like my singing. I can tell by the way you look down at your pad, pretending there's some very important information you have to write down for the captain. Well, you don't like my singing, and I didn't like what they were doing to Elvis. So that's why I did something about it.

Oh, I heard when you said it's not about arrest. "You're merely conducting an investigation into potentially improper expenditure of government funds." What are you? FBI? Or was it the Food and Drug Administration -- the FDA? Or did you say the FTC? Or the CDC? All those people in all those agencies with all those letters who are all interested in investigating DNA. And Elvis. And little old me.

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Well, you can bust me if you want to. I don't care. All those letters get right to the heart of the problem. I saw it when I first went back into biology. I discovered that people had lost the feel of things.

Like take DNA. That's all wrong. Three lousy letters. It's deoxyribonucleic acid. God, I love the sound of it so much. Deoxyribonucleic acid. Deoxyribonucleic acid. I feel like I'm making beautiful music every time I say it. And it's just one part. When you really get behind deoxyribonucleic acid -- put your body and feeling and emotion under DNA -- deoxyribonucleic acid -- ahhh ...that is fine. Really, really fine.

(SHE says the last line as if SHE is in love.) But even really fine things need tender loving care. *(SHE stands, as if stepping back into the lab.)*

The director gave a little seminar to all of us new people when I was first hired at the lab. *(SHE becomes the director.)*

"One day because of our work on something invisible to the eye -- DNA -- we will begin to know the complete identity of humans. We will know every nucleotide, every A, C, G and T inside the human body, all three billion elements of the interior code that defines a person completely, making an exact blueprint for every human being."

Suffice to say, I was about the oldest one there. I'd come back to biology after having two kids. So maybe my understanding of history was a little different -- at least on certain points. I'd sit and listen at lunch hour. *(She becomes three other technicians.)*

"Imagine," said one, "if we could figure out the complete DNA code of one really famous person."

"Yeah," said another, "even if DNA has three billion elements, that's still quantifiable. It's not infinity."

"And there is money in it. People are willing to put up investment capital for DNA banks, that kind of thing."

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"But you'd need one really famous person."

"There's Einstein ..."

"Not splashy enough."

"Queen Elizabeth."

"No one really cares."

"Shakespeare."

"Too esoteric."

(To investigator.)

These names went round and round like a hound dog crying all the time, and, as I recall, that's when Elvis first came up.

(As the characters.)

"Think about all the Elvis imitators."

"If -- we could actually discover Elvis' complete DNA code..."

"and alter a person's genes to make a new Elvis, a real Elvis, someone with the exact genetic makeup of Elvis, we'd be ..."

"Rich."

(To investigator.)

"Rich." That's what they said. How could they understand? Watson and Crick only discovered the double helix one year before "That's All Right, Mama." The people in the labs were so-o young. They had no perspective.

Think of it. If these people really understood DNA -- or Elvis -- they would listen to the words -- roll them around in their mouths, let them melt under their

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tongues, and then let them out gently, mellifluously, with tenderness. Take the DNA bases. Even the director called them by their initials: A or G or C or T. When the words are so marvelous -- "Adenine." "Guanine." "Cytosine." "Thymine." But all the people in the labs say are A or G or C or T. As if you could sing 'Don't be C' and that would suffice for "cruel" or 'don't step on my B Suede Shoes' and that would make up for "blue." No, I believe that people in the labs have no concept of the artistic.

Still, I didn't pay much mind. I took the lunch discussions as idle chatter. Because it didn't seem really possible. And then more and more things kept happening. New testing. New equipment. Funding. Grants. More genes on the genome were identified. The pace accelerated. And then one day people were huddled in a corner.

(Acting as other characters.)

"If someone pretended to be a journalist and got an interview with Lisa-Marie, and then Lisa-Marie had something to drink, and we got the saliva off the rim of the glass, and extracted DNA ..."

"You'd still only have offspring with Elvis and Priscilla's DNA. There's a better way. Elvis had a twin, but the twin died at birth. No one knows exactly where the twin is buried. But twins, if they are identical, have the same DNA. So if we went down to Tupelo with one of those laser probes, and found the body of ..."

"Wait. We can keep it simple. If one of us visited Graceland and got a swab off an item of clothing -- where he sweated, the armpits or collar, for example on the gold lame suit or the karate robe -- we could test that."

(To investigator)

I still didn't think anything of it. But then one day, one of the technicians mentioned that he was taking a vacation in Memphis. Everyone else nodded and smiled.

I'm not paranoid. I saw it with my own eyes. My back stiffened. Elvis' song, "Don't," started pumping through my brain, as if he were singing to me personally.

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(Confidentially.) They were working on a secret plan to identify the entire genetic code of Elvis, which they planned to sell to a commercial entity for harvesting -- to recreate Elvis. And it was happening right here in a research lab supported with government money.

(More voluble.) I want you to understand one thing. I am not a fanatic. I am not one of those people who celebrates Elvis' birth and memorializes his death. I don't make pilgrimages to Graceland. But they didn't understand Elvis at all.

See, DNA, genes -- they don't tell the whole story. Because you could know every vowel in "Love Me Tender" and sing every note, like I do. But you still wouldn't be Elvis. You still wouldn't have that wonderful curl at the end of a phrase, that little hiccup of delight that injects surprise, that deep boom and slow slide up, the saving grace, that made Elvis. Notes don't make a song, and you could name all the genes in a person's body, but you wouldn't have a singer. You wouldn't have his smile; the eyes that could take in an audience; his soul.

After this technician came back, my suspicions grew. I noticed a group of people working late each night. There were hushed conversations, passed notes, winking and blinking. They always seemed intent on ushering me out the door as soon as possible at the end of the work day.

I watched this for several days. And then I couldn't take it anymore. While they were at lunch, I snuck to the back and stole the key to the locked refrigerator from one of the drawers. Then I opened the refrigerator. And just as I suspected there were fresh vials in there. Vials marked "E," like "E-1," "E-2," E-3." You know what that meant.

And there were notes on one of the tables. Had "G Information" on them, and that stood for Graceland. My suspicions were confirmed.

After that, I didn't waste any time. I knew what I had to do. I had to save Elvis.

I took the "E" "1-2-3" vials, stuck them in my shirt, checked out with the guard, flashing my badge, of course, and walked out the door, down to the strip -- the commercial strip -- looking for the right place. I came to a toy store and I knew

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that's what he wanted. I could hear him singing to me, "I only want to be your teddy bear." I poured out the vials on the sidewalk. 1-2-3. And then I smashed the vials. 1-2-3. I destroyed private property. And then I tore up the notes into little bits, and destroyed some more.

And I'm the one left all those no-name messages with you and every other high-'faluting agency I could think of and said there was something you ought to know. You're just the first to show.

But I don't care if you know my name anymore. "I don't care if the sun don't shine." Because there will be only one King.

(Hums 'Love Me Tender.' Sits back down.) The name'sJaneanne. So does that answer all of your questions?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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